

Japanese female idol nicknames: A linguistic analysis¹

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Abstract

In Japan, female idols have been debuting since the 1970s. Their nicknames during the 1970s and 1980s predominantly followed one pattern: the use of the suffix *-tan*. However, nicknaming patterns began to diversify starting in the 2000s. This study aims to conduct phonological and morpho-phonological analyses of the nicknaming patterns derived from the Japanese Female Idol Nickname Database (J-FIND) established by the author. The findings indicate that the predominant process is suffixation with *-tan* and its variants, including *-pon*, *-tan*, and *-rin*, which together comprise 36.8%, approximately one-third of the nicknames in the database. Other nicknaming patterns include reduplication, truncation, h→p alternation, reversing argot, vowel lengthening, gemination, and combinations of several of these processes.

Keywords: Japanese, nicknames, phonology, morphology

1. Introduction

Idols are generally defined as entertainers who sing, dance, act, or model across various media, including television and live events. They epitomize Japanese culture and have garnered significant scholarly interest in sociology and cultural studies (e.g., Aoyagi 2005; Galbraith 2018; Galbraith & Karlin 2012, 2019; Kiuchi 2017). This study aims to analyse Japanese female idol nicknames from the perspectives of phonology and morphology in linguistics. Because a comprehensive database of female idol nicknames does not exist, the author of this study established the Japanese Female Idol Nickname Database (J-FIND). This analysis relies on the aforementioned database.

The linguistics literature on nicknames (e.g., Alber 2010; Alber & Kokkelmans 2022; Brdar et al. 2023; Cabré et al. 2021; Cohn 2005; Grüter 2003; Kentner 2023; Lappe 2007; Lipski 1995; Lubowicz et al. 2007; Nelson 1998; Piñeros 2000a, b; Plénat 1999, 2003; Thornton 2023; Wiese 2001; Wong 2003) demonstrates that languages generate nicknames by incorporating part or all of the original name through various (morpho-)phonological processes, including truncation, affixation, and reduplication, as illustrated in (1).

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(1) Morpho-phonological processes to create nicknames in different languages

a. Truncation

English	<i>Elizabeth</i> → <i>Liz, Beth</i> <i>David</i> → <i>Dave</i>	(Lappe 2007)
German	<i>Katharina</i> → <i>Kath</i> <i>Matthias</i> → <i>Hias</i>	(Alber & Kokkelmans 2022)
Indonesian	<i>Agus</i> → <i>Gus</i> <i>Mochtar</i> → <i>Tar</i>	(Cohn 2005)
Italian	<i>Francesca</i> → <i>France, Cesca</i> <i>Andrea</i> → <i>Andre</i>	(Alber 2010)
Sardinian	<i>Filumena</i> → <i>Mena</i> <i>Servatore</i> → <i>Vatore</i>	(Cabr�� et al. 2021)
Spanish	<i>David</i> → <i>Davi</i> <i>Valentino</i> → <i>Tino</i>	(Pi��eros 2000a, b)

b. Affixation

Bernese Swiss German	<i>Lukas</i> → <i>L��ku</i> <i>Adolf</i> → <i>D��lfu</i>	(Gr��ter 2003)
English	<i>Elizabeth</i> → <i>Lizzy</i> <i>Edward</i> → <i>Eddie</i>	(Lappe 2007)
German	<i>Andreas</i> → <i>Andi</i> <i>Rudolf</i> → <i>Rudi</i>	(Wiese 2001)
Hungarian	<i>Ferenc</i> → <i>Feri, Fec��</i> <i>Zolt��n</i> → <i>Zoli, Zol��</i>	(Brdar et al. 2023)
Polish	<i>Karol</i> → <i>Karolek</i> <i>Agat</i> → <i>Agatka</i>	(Lubowicz et al. 2007)
Spanish	<i>Valentin</i> → <i>Tino</i> <i>Isabel</i> → <i>Bela</i>	(Lipski 1995)

c. Reduplication

Chinese	<i>Lay Nee</i> → <i>Nee Nee</i> <i>Bee Pheng</i> → <i>Peng Peng</i>	(Wong 2003)
French	<i>Thomas</i> → <i>Toto</i> <i>Monique</i> → <i>Momo, Nini</i>	(Nelson 1998; Pl��nat 1999)
German	<i>Johannes</i> → <i>Jojo</i> <i>Luise</i> → <i>Lulu</i>	(Kentner 2023)
Hungarian	<i>Piroska</i> → <i>Pipi</i> <i>Am��lia</i> → <i>Lili</i>	(Brdar et al. 2023)
Italian	<i>Luigi</i> → <i>Gigi</i> <i>Elisabetta</i> → <i>Lilli</i>	(Alber 2010; Thornton 2023)
Spanish	<i>Susana</i> → <i>Nana</i> <i>Socorro</i> → <i>Coco</i>	(Pl��nat 2003)

Similar to these languages, Japanese also employs such processes to generate nicknames (e.g., Bare  ov   2020; Hashimoto 2016; Ito 1990; Kawahara et al. 2019; Kubozono 1999; Mester 1990; Morioka & Yamaguchi 1985; Poser 1984, 1990). In the context of Japanese female idol nicknames, we observe various (morpho-)phonological processes, such as

segmental alternation, reversing argot, vowel lengthening, and gemination. This study examines their nicknames with respect to these (morpho-)phonological processes.

The remainder of this article is structured as follows. Section 2 provides an overview of the history of Japanese idols and their nicknames. Section 3 outlines the methodology used to collect the nicknames that comprise the J-FIND. Section 4 examines various nicknaming processes identified in the J-FIND, including suffixation, reduplication, truncation, h→p alternation, reversing argot (also known as *Zuujiya-go*), vowel lengthening, and gemination. Section 5 summarises the article.

2. Background: Japanese idols and their nicknames

This section provides a brief history of idols before examining idol nicknames. In Japan, idols began to emerge during the 1970s (Galbraith & Karlin 2019). A notable example is the duo named *Pink Lady*, comprising *Mitsuyo Nemoto* and *Keiko Masuda*. The 1980s are recognised as the “golden age of idols,” marked by the debut of numerous stars, including *Seiko Matsuda*. The prominence of idols declined in the late 1980s, a period often referred to as the “idol ice age”. However, in 1985, *the Onyanko Club* emerged and redefined the idol archetype. This idol group garnered numerous fans by creating a distinct image, portraying idols not as ‘sacred’ individuals with exceptional talent detached from everyday life. Subsequently, *Morning Musume* (debuted in 1997) and *AKB48* (debuted in 2005), embodying the concept of “idols you can go to meet,” have attained significant prominence in Japanese idol history. Currently, idols continue to debut annually in Japan.

Idols who debuted in the 1970s and 1980s often had distinctive nicknames that frequently included the suffix *-tyan* /tɛaŋ/ (e.g., *Mitsuyo Nemoto* → *Mii-tyan*; *Keiko Masuda* → *Kei-tyan*; *Seiko Matsuda* → *Seiko-tyan*). However, since around 2000, nicknaming patterns have become more diverse (Kumagai 2025). One possible explanation for this trend is the large number of idols produced in Japan. To help fans recognise newly debuting idols, unique nicknames were assigned to each, resulting in a wide variety of nicknames within the idol community.

3. The Japanese female idol nickname database

As stated in Section 1, there is no comprehensive database on idol nicknames. Therefore, the author created the Japanese Female Idol Nickname Database (J-FIND) by utilizing the online resources from Wikipedia related to Japanese idol groups², as well as relevant official websites and individual blogs of the idols. With the diversification of idol nicknames beginning in the 2000s, the database was designed to focus on groups that debuted between 2000 and 2019. Consequently, 4,010 pairs of idols and their corresponding nicknames were collected, encompassing 217 idol groups. The database includes both “official” and “unofficial”

² <https://ja.wikipedia.org/wiki/日本の女性アイドルグループの一覧>

nicknames. Official nicknames are assigned by the talent agencies to which the idols belong, while unofficial nicknames are given by fans.

From the original set of 4,010 nickname-idol pairs, several were excluded from the analysis. First, 88 pairs were removed due to overlap caused by the reassignment of certain idols to different groups. Second, 457 pairs were excluded because they deviated from standard Japanese orthography; these included nicknames such as “なあな”, those incorporating Chinese characters like “姫”, and alphabets, such as “ま a な”, the inclusion of symbols like an exclamation mark (!), or nicknames that were not derived from original names. Third, 638 pairs were omitted because the author could not determine whether the idol had a personal nickname, or the correct pronunciation of her original name. Ultimately, 2,827 pairs remained.

4. Analysis

The following sections analyse the nicknames identified in the J-FIND dataset with respect to (morpho-)phonological processes. The relevant data can be found in the Excel file, which is available at the Open Science Framework repository (<https://osf.io/kz8ym>).

4.1 Suffixation using *-tyan* and its variants

A highly productive process to create nicknames in Japanese involves adding the bimoraic suffix *-tyan* /tɛan/. Typically, this suffix is appended to abbreviated names that are two-mora, or one-foot, in length, as illustrated in (2a) (e.g., Itô 1990; Kubozono 1999; Poser 1984, 1990). Additionally, the suffix exhibits multiple variants, as demonstrated in (2b) (Hashimoto 2016:5; Morioka & Yamaguchi 1985:169; Poser 1984, 1990). A common pattern is the addition of a bimoraic variant following a bimoraic base name, resulting in a four-mora nickname (Hashimoto 2016).

(2) Nicknames using the suffix *-tyan* /tɛan/ and its variants

a. Abbreviated (bimoraic) name + the suffix /tɛan/

Keiko → Kei-tyan Makoto → Mako-tyan Sachiko → Sat-tyan

b. Variants of the suffix /tɛan/

Yoshiko → Yoc-chin [tɛin]	Keiko → Kei-pin [pin]
Kieko → Kie-non [non]	Kaori → Kao-tan [tan]
Megumi → Megu-min [min]	Mirena → Rena-pyon [pʲon]

The present analysis is provided below. Among the 2,827 pairs of idols and nicknames, there were 1,041 instances (=36.8%) that contained /CVN/, including the suffixes *-tyan* /tɛan/, *-san* /san/ (an honorific), *-kun* /kun/ (used for male nicknames), and their variants. Table 1 displays the length of nicknames with these suffixes. The predominant pattern consisted of four moras, as observed by Hashimoto (2016). Among the 1,041 instances, the following analysis

excluded 25 non-standard cases (see (3)): 12 instances involving a reversing process known as *Zuujya-go*, or musician’s language, in Japanese, and 13 instances that overlapped with existing words, either partially or fully. Consequently, 1,016 instances of /CVN/ suffixes remained.

Table 1. The length of nicknames with /CVN/

	3 moras	4 moras	5 moras	6 moras and longer	ALL
ALL	11	942	84	4	1,041
<i>-tyan</i> , <i>-san</i> , <i>-kun</i> , and their variants	11	922	79	4	1,016
non-standard	0	20	5	0	25

(3) Non-standard cases in the idol nicknames

a. *Zuujya-go*, or musician’s language

Aya [aja] (name) + *-tyan* [tean] → [tean-aja]

b. Overlapping with existing words

Riko [riko] (name) + *-pin* [pin] → [rikopin]

(cf. /rikopin/ “lycopene”)

Manami [manami] (name) + *-kan* [kan] → [manamikan]

(cf. /mikan/ “orange”)

Anna [anna] (name) + *-nin* [nin] → [annin]

(cf. /annin do:ɸu/ “almond jelly/ almond tofu”)

Ai [ai] (name) + *-hon* [hon] → [aihon]

(cf. /aihon/ “i-Phone”)

Hasumi [hasumi] (name) + *-wan* [wan] → [hasuwan]

(cf. /suwan/ “swan”)

Table 2 categorises the 1,016 instances according to the basic suffixes *-tyan*, *-san*, *-kun*, and their variants, based on mora length. Among these instances, the suffix *-tyan* was the most prevalent, followed by the /CVN/ variants.

Table 2. The number of the basic suffixes *-tyan*, *-san*, *-kun*, and their variants (Excel sheet 1)

	3 moras	4 moras	5 moras	6 moras and longer	ALL
ALL	11	922	79	4	1,016
<i>-tyan</i>	4	495	51	3	553
<i>-kun</i>	0	3	2	0	5
<i>-san</i>	0	19	4	1	24
variants	7	405	22	0	434

We examined 434 instances of the /CVN/ variants below. Among these instances, we identified 36 types of variants³, surpassing the cases reported in Hashimoto (2016) and Morioka and Yamaguchi (1985). Examples of nicknames using the /CVN/ variants in the J-FIND dataset are illustrated in (4).

(4) Idol nicknames using the /CVN/ variants

/p/	Ayaka → Aya-pan [paN]	Mao-pin [piN]
	Ririka → Riri-pon [poN]	
/t/	Kaori → Kao-tan [taN]	Ruka → Ruka-tin [tiN]
	Yui → Yui-ten [teN]	Rio → Rio-ton [toN]
/k/	Misaki → Misa-ken [keN]	
/b/	Sana → Sana-bun [buN]	Kana → Kana-bon [boN]
/d/	Sae → Sae-don [doN]	
/g/	Takahata → Hata-gon [goN]	
/ts/	Yamaguchi → Yamagut-tsan [tsaN]	Yuki → Yuki-tsun [tsuN]
/tɕ/	Tomomi → Tomo-chin [tɕiN]	Mai → Mai-chun [tɕuN]
	Saki → Saki-chon [tɕoN]	
/ɸ/	Yuuka → Yuka-fin [ɸiN]	
/ɕ/	Megumi → Megu-syan [ɕaN]	Aya → Ayas-syon [ɕoN]
/h/	Yui → Yui-han [haN]	
/m/	Anna → Anna-man [maN]	Mina → Mina-min [miN]
	Sena → Sena-mun [muN]	Hashimoto → Hashi-mon [moN]
/n/	Yuki → Yuki-non [noN]	
/r/	Miho → Mipo-rin [riN]	Mina → Mina-run [ruN]
	Tomoyo → Tomo-ron [roN]	
/j/	Saki → Saki-yan [jaN]	
/pʲ/	Rika → Rika-pyon [pʲoN]	
/kʲ/	Mayu → Mayu-kyan [kʲaN]	Nemu → Nemu-kyun [kʲuN]
	Tomoka → Tomo-kyon [kʲoN]	
/mʲ/	Sae → Sae-myon [mʲoN]	
/nʲ/	Marina → Mari-nyan [nʲaN]	

Table 3 presents the distribution of the /CVN/ variants. A few notes are in order. First, certain consonants known as allophones can be phonemic in nicknames, as well as in loanwords. For example, [ts] is an allophone of /t/ before /u/, and [ɸ] is an allophone of /h/ before /u/ (Labrune 2012), but idol nicknames permit sequences such as [tsa] or [ɸi], as loanwords do. Second, /dzu/ and /zu/ are phonetically the same (Labrune 2012), but they are distinguished from each other in terms of orthography: /dzu/ = “づ”, /zu/ = “ず”. Third, palatalised consonants such as /pʲ/ and /kʲ/ are considered as single consonants, rather than consonant clusters. Fourth, the suffixes *-tyan*, *-san*, *-kun*, represented by the asterisk (*), are not counted. Fifth, phonotactically impermissible sequences in Japanese are presented as the hyphen (-), rather than “0”.

³ If the case of overlapping with an existing word is included, we can add [kaN], [niN], [hoN], and [waN] (see (3b)).

Table 3. The distribution of the /CV_N/ variants (Excel sheet 1)

V C	/a/	/i/	/u/	/e/	/o/	ALL
/p/	8	2	0	0	40	50
/t/	113	9	0	10	2	134
/k/	0	0	*	1	0	1
/b/	0	0	2	0	1	3
/d/	0	0	0	0	2	2
/g/	0	0	0	0	2	2
/tɕ/	*	24	8	0	2	34
/dʑ/	0	0	0	0	0	0
/ts/	1	0	6	0	0	7
/dʒ/	0	0	0	0	0	0
/ɸ/	0	1	0	0	0	1
/s/	*	-	0	0	0	0
/ɕ/	3	0	0	0	1	4
/ç/	0	0	0	0	0	0
/h/	1	-	-	0	0	1
/z/	0	-	0	0	0	0
/ʑ/	0	0	0	0	0	0
/m/	1	3	1	0	5	10
/n/	0	0	0	0	2	2
/r/	0	51	8	0	1	60
/w/	0	0	-	0	0	0
/j/	6	-	0	0	0	6
/p ^j /	0	-	0	-	38	38
/b ^j /	0	-	0	-	0	0
/m ^j /	0	-	0	-	1	1
/k ^j /	11	-	10	-	2	23
/g ^j /	0	-	0	-	0	0
/n ^j /	55	-	0	-	0	55
/r ^j /	0	-	0	-	0	0
ALL	199	90	35	11	99	434

To summarise this section, the database indicated that approximately one-third of all female idol nicknames featured the suffix *-tyan* /tean/ or its variant. Additionally, as many as 36 types of /CV_N/ variants were identified, exceeding previous reports in the literature. This suggests that using the suffix *-tyan* /tean/ or its variant is the most productive process for creating idol nicknames. Interested readers are encouraged to consult Kumagai (2025) for a sound symbolic analysis of the onset variable of these variants.

4.2 Reduplication

Reduplication is commonly observed in Japanese nicknames, as identified by previous studies (e.g., Barešová 2020; Hashimoto 2016; Kawahara et al. 2019). Nicknames featuring reduplication in the J-FIND dataset can be categorised into three patterns, as shown in (5). In

the first pattern (5a), the last mora (CV) of the (bimoraic) name (base) is reduplicated. In the second pattern (5b), the coda-nasal /N/ is added to the first pattern. In the third pattern (5c), the bimoraic base (CVCV) is reduplicated.

(5) Idol nicknames using reduplication

a. CV reduplication

Rima → Rima-ma [rimama]	Amu → Amu-mu [amumu]
Rena → Rena-na [renana]	Haruka → Paru-ru [paruru]
Miwa → Miwa-wa [miwawa]	Mayu → Mayu-yu [majuju]

b. CV reduplication + /N/-addition

Mana → Mana-na-n [mananan]	Honoka → Hono-no-n [hononon]
Sara → Sara-ra-n [sararan]	Miria → Miri-ri-n [miririn]
Haruka → Haru-ru-n [harurun]	Kayoko → Kayo-yo-n [kajojon]

c. CVCV reduplication

Konatsu → Kona-kona [konakona]	Jun → Jun-jun [dzundzun]
Kyoka → Kyon-kyon [kʲonkʲon]	Mai → Mai-mai [maimai]
Miyu → Miyu-miyu [mijumiju]	Rei → Rei-rei [reirei]

In (5a), most nicknames either increase in length or remain unchanged (e.g., *Rima* → *Rima-ma*; *Haruka* → *Paruru*). Conversely, there are a limited number of examples that become shorter (e.g., *Megumi* → *Meme*; *Nozomi* → *Nono*). This pattern, known as truncated CV-reduplication, was uncommon in the J-FIND, in contrast to the instances observed in the European languages (1c).

Kawahara et al. (2019) elucidated a sound symbolic trend indicating that reduplicated consonants are more likely to favour sonorants than obstruents in female idol nicknames. The present analysis focused on the first consonant (C₁) in the three reduplication patterns to validate this trend. Table 4 presents the results, with the third column, “φ,” indicating names that begin without a consonant.

Table 4. The number of the first consonant (C₁) sonority in reduplication (Excel sheet 2)

	C ₁	sonorants	obstruents	φ	ALL
C ₁ V reduplication		55 (91.7%)	5 (8.3%)	0 (0%)	60
C ₁ V reduplication + /N/-addition		42 (100%)	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	42
C ₁ VC ₂ V reduplication		94 (79.66%)	12 (10.17%)	12 (10.17%)	118

The leftmost column shows that a sonorant is preferred for the C₁ position over an obstruent. This preference is attributed to the sound symbolic trend, as demonstrated by Shinohara and Kawahara (2013), that sonorants are generally favoured in female names.

4.3 Truncation (Clipping)

Truncation, or clipping, is a common process to create nicknames in Japanese (Barešová 2020; Hashimoto 2016; Kubozono 2015). There are two patterns of truncation. The first involves truncating either the given or family name; this is known as single-word truncation. Concerning the location of clipping within the name, four possible patterns exist, as illustrated in (6a): back-clipping, fore-clipping, fore-and-back clipping, and mid-clipping. For example, *Yoshinobu* (given name) is truncated to *Yoshi* in back-clipping, to *Nobu* in fore-clipping, to *Shino* in fore-and-back clipping, and to *Yobu* in mid-clipping, respectively. In the second pattern, both the given and family names are truncated and then compounded. Clipping types are referred to as “X+Y” patterns (according to Tanaka 2020), wherein X moras from the family name and Y moras from the given name are adopted for nicknames. (6b) presents examples of “2+2”, “1+2”, “2+1,” and “3+1” patterns.

(6) Truncation types

a. Single-word truncation

back-clipping	Yoshinobu → Yoshi [joei]
fore-clipping	Yoshinobu → Nobu [nobi]
fore-and-back clipping	Yoshinobu → Shino [cino]
clipping	
mid-clipping	Yoshinobu → Yobu [jobu]

b. Compound truncation

“2+2”	Yamamoto Yoshinobu → Yama-yoshi [jamajoei]
“1+2”	Yamamoto Yoshinobu → Ya-yoshi [jajoei]
“2+1”	Yamamoto Yoshinobu → Yama-yo [jamajo]
“3+1”	Yamamoto Yoshinobu → Yamamo-yo [jamamojo]

The clipping process was also observed in female idol nicknames. Examples in (7) illustrate the nicknames using truncation as identified in the J-FIND. The predominant pattern of single-word truncation was back-clipping, forming a bimoraic nickname (Table 5). We identified four patterns for compound truncation: “2+2”, “1+2”, “2+1”, and “3+1” in the J-FIND, as shown in (7b). The “2+2” pattern was employed more frequently than the other patterns (Table 6). Furthermore, we identified nicknames incorporating an additional phonological process, as presented in (7c).

(7) Idol nicknames using truncation

a. Single-word truncation

back-clipping	Nagisa → Nagi [nagi] Narumi → Naru [naru] Sakurako → Saku [saku] Kawaoto → Kawao [kawao]
fore-clipping	Kanon → Non [non] Yoshizumi → Zumi [zumi] Sakurako → Rako [rako]
fore-and-back clipping	Azuki → Zu [zu]

b. Compound truncation

“2+2”	Kitahara Rie → Kita-rie [kitarie] Komiyama Haruka → Komi-haru [komiharu]
“1+2”	Yumoto Ami → Yu-ami [juami] Gotoo Maki → Go-maki [gomaki]
“2+1”	Miyazaki Rina → Miya-ri [mijari] Shimizu Riko → Shimi-ko [eimiko]
“3+1”	Haruna Hikaru → Haruna-hi [harunaçi]

c. Compound truncation (with a further process added)

“2+2”	Izuta Rina → Izu-riina [izuri:na] (+ mora lengthening)
“2+2”	Miyahana Momo → Miya-momo-tyan [mijamomotean] (+ suffixation)
“1+2”	Hidaka Nanoka → Daa-nano [da:nano] (+ mora lengthening)
“2+1”	Sakurai Rio → Rai-rii [rairi:] (+ mora lengthening)
“2+1”	Tanabe Miku → Tana-min [tanamin] (+ /N/-addition)

Table 5. Four patterns in single-word truncation (Excel sheet 3)

Patterns	back	fore	fore-and-back	mid	ALL
ALL	67	12	1	0	80
1 mora	0	0	1	-	1
2 moras	66	11	0	0	77
3 moras	1	1	0	0	2

Table 6. Patterns in compound truncation (Excel sheet 3)

Patterns	“1+2”	“2+1”	“2+2”	“3+1”	ALL
ALL	11	15	47	1	74
3 moras	10	8	-	-	18
4 moras	1	7	45	1	54
5 moras	0	0	1	0	1
6 moras	0	0	1	0	1

4.4 h→p alternation

In Japanese, there exists an alternation that transforms /h/ into [pp] word-medially in both native and Sino-Japanese (SJ) words (e.g., Ito et al. 2017; Labrune 2012), referred to as the h→p alternation (see (8)). There is also a sound symbolic h→p alternation that makes a name sound cute (Kumagai 2019, 2023). For example, we have a nicknaming process called *pime-yobi* “princess-calling,” in which the word *hime* “princess” becomes [pime] when attached after a base name such as *Ayu* (e.g., *Ayu-pime* “Princess Ayu”).

(8) Examples of h→p alternation in native and SJ words

a. Native words

/suki/ ‘empty’ + /hara/ ‘stomach’ → /suki[pp]ara/ ‘empty stomach’
 /dasi/ ‘to emit (conjunctive)’ + /hanasi/ ‘to release (nominative)’
 → /dasi[pp]anasi/ ‘to keep emitting’

b. SJ words

/situ/ ‘lose’ (失) + /hai/ ‘lose’ (敗) → /si[pp]ai/ ‘failure’
 /zetu/ ‘extinct’ (絶) + /han/ ‘version’ (版) → /ze[pp]an/ ‘out of print’

We identified 19 instances of sound symbolic h→p alternation in the J-FIND, as shown in (9). For example, *Haruka* transforms to *Paruru*, and *Fuuka* [ɸu:ka] becomes *Pukka* [pukka] (in the latter case, [ɸ] is realised as an allophone of /h/). These examples demonstrate that the sound symbolic h→p alternation applies not only to common nouns but also to proper nouns.

(9) Idol nicknames using h→p alternation

Haruka → Paruru [paruru] Riho → Ripopo [ripopo]
 Hikaru → Pikarun [pikaruN] Fuuka → Pukka [pukka]
 Homura → Pomu [pomu]

4.5 Zuuja-go

In Japanese, there is reversing argot known as *Zuuja-go*, or musician’s language (Itô et al. 1996; Poser 1990; Tateishi 1989). Numerous output forms consist of either three- or four-mora

long. Thus, vowel (or mora) lengthening occurs to satisfy the condition when the input form consists of only one- or two-mora long, as shown in the third and fourth examples in (10).

(10) Zuuja-go

hurusato ‘hometown’ → satohuru [satoɸuru]	
ginza ‘Ginza’ (city name) → zagin [zaɡin]	
sushi ‘sushi’ → shiisuu [ɕi:su:]	jyazu ‘jazz’ → zuuja [zu:dza]
hi ‘fire’ → iihii [i:ɕi:]	me ‘eye’ → eeme [e:me:]

We identified 17 instances using the reversing process in the J-FIND, all of which consist of either three- or four-mora long. Examples are provided in (11).

(11) Idol nicknames using Zuuja-go

Mariko → Komari [komari]	
Marukawa Koyuki → Yukimaru [jukimaru]	
Yokoi Honami → Honayo [honajo]	Suda → Daasuu [da:su:]
Tamae Uta → Utama [u:tama]	Arisa → Asarin [asarin]

4.6 Vowel lengthening and gemination

Vowel (or mora) lengthening and gemination are evident in Japanese nicknames. An illustrative example arises from nicknames incorporating the suffix *-tyan*. As previously indicated in Section 4.1, abbreviated names preceding the suffix must be two-mora, or one-foot, long (e.g., Itô 1990; Poser 1984, 1990). This condition is occasionally satisfied through vowel lengthening or gemination; for example, *Misato* becomes *Misa-tyan*, *Mii-tyan* (vowel lengthening), or *Mit-tyan* (gemination) (Kubozono 1999, 2023).

Additionally, vowel lengthening and gemination are used to establish a preferred phonological form. Hashimoto (2016) contends that in the analysis of female idol nicknames, trimoraic nicknames derived from a bimoraic base predominantly favour Heavy-Light patterns over Light-Heavy patterns; for example, when the base form is CV.CV, we favour CVV.CV and CVC.CV (HL) over CV.CVV (LH)⁴. This pattern is formed through vowel lengthening and gemination (e.g., [na.na] ‘Nana’ → [na:.na] (CVV.CV); [suzuki] ‘Suzuki’ → [zuk.ki] (CVC.CV)).

This analysis presents instances of vowel lengthening and gemination, irrespective of nickname length. In the J-FIND, we identified 54 instances of vowel lengthening as exemplified in (12), and 67 instances of gemination as illustrated in (13).

⁴ This trend of phonological forms is also observed in Japanese motherese (Kubozono 2019).

(12) Idol nicknames using vowel lengthening

Miyu → Miiyu [mi:ju]	Yuuka → Uuka [u:ka]	Ao → Aao [a:o]
Ami → Aamin [a:miN]	Mari → Maarin [ma:riN]	
Riru → Riiruu [ri:ru:]	Aida → Aiida [ai:da]	Akina → Akkiina [akki:na]

(13) Idol nicknames using gemination

Yurika → Yukka [jukka]	Taguchi → Tagucchi [taguttei]
Saki → Sakkii [sakki:]	Sashihara → Sasshii [saæci:]
Misuzu → Missuu [missu:]	Saho → Sakhoo [sahho:]

The current analysis uncovered a novel finding that vowel lengthening is more likely to occur before sonorants than before obstruents (“φ” = no onset consonant) (Table 7; (14)). It is unclear, however, why the consonant type can induce vowel lengthening.

Table 7. Consonant types following vowel lengthening (Excel sheet 6)

sonorants	voiceless obstruents	voiced obstruents	φ	ALL
41	8	2	3	54

(14) Idol nicknames using vowel lengthening

a. Sonorants

Ami → Aamin [a:miN]	Mirei → Miire [mi:re]	Mari → Maarin [ma:riN]
Miyu → Miiyu [mi:ju]	Akina → Akkiina [akki:na]	
Saya → Saaya [sa:ja]	Riru → Riiruu [ri:ru:]	

b. Voiceless obstruents

Yuuka → Uuka [u:ka]	Uta → Uutan [u:tan]	Ako → Aako [a:ko]
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c. Voiced obstruents

Yoda → Yooda [jo:da]	Aida → Aiida [ai:da]
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d. Other

Mion → Miion [mi:ON]	Ao → Aao [a:o]
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Conversely, the relationship between consonant types and gemination is evident; all geminated consonants in the J-FIND were voiceless obstruents (Table 8).

Table 8. Consonant types of geminated consonants (Excel sheet 7)

voiceless obstruents	voiced obstruents	liquids	glides	ALL
67	0	0	0	67

There was no example demonstrating gemination of voiced obstruents, liquids, and glides. This resulted from phonotactic restrictions in Japanese. Voiced obstruents and flap /ɾ/ are allowed to geminate only in loanwords (e.g., Itô & Mester 1995, 1999; Kawahara & Kumagai 2024; Kumagai to appear). Additionally, gemination of glides /w, j/ is allowed only while expressing emphasis (e.g., /kowa-i/ ‘scaring’ → [kowwa:i], /haja-i/ ‘fast’ → [hajja:i]; see Kawahara 2015; Kawahara & Pangilinan 2017 for details).

5. Concluding remarks

This study presented a phonological and morpho-phonological analysis of Japanese female idol nicknames, highlighting the diversification of nicknaming patterns since the 2000s. We found that the predominant morpho-phonological process to create nicknames is suffixation with *-tyan* or its variants, accounting for approximately 36.8% of the nicknames analysed in this research. The nicknames also exhibited other (morpho-)phonological processes, including three types of reduplication, two types of truncation, and the sound symbolic h→p alternation. Furthermore, various nicknames are generated through a reversing process (*Zuujya-go*), vowel lengthening, or gemination. Nicknames with other suffixes, such as CV, CVR (=CV:/) and CVCV, are listed on the last three sheets of the Excel file.

This research presents two primary findings. First, there are 36 distinct variants of the suffix *-tyan*, significantly exceeding those reported in the previous studies (Hashimoto 2016; Morioka & Yamaguchi 1985). Second, we identified nicknames that exhibit a sound symbolic h→p alternation, which is a novel nicknaming process (Kumagai 2019, 2023). Future research is expected to examine whether the nicknaming patterns for female idols will be more diverse in later years.

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